

Bewakoof : From India's Coolest D2C Fashion Brand to Losing Relevance

Between **2016 and 2021**, if you were a college student or young professional in India, chances are you owned at least one Bewakoof T-shirt. It was one of India's strongest D2C (Direct-to-Consumer) fashion success stories.

Yet today, despite still operating, it is rarely mentioned alongside brands like Zudio, Uniqlo, Souled Store or even fast-fashion newcomers.

The company didn't exactly "die."
It became **irrelevant**.

That's an even more interesting business story.

Company Background

Founded in **2012**

Founders:

- Prabhkiran Singh
- Siddharth Munot

Started with a simple observation:

Indian youth wanted affordable clothes with personality.

At that time:

- Fashion was expensive
- Branded T-shirts cost ₹800–1500
- Youth wanted funny graphics
- Online shopping was exploding

Instead of competing with premium brands...

Bewakoof built a brand around

"Being proudly weird."

Hence the name **Bewakoof**.

Phase 1 (2012–2015): Solving the Right Problem

Their early strategy was brilliant.

Instead of selling fashion...

They sold identity.

Examples:

- Sarcastic quotes
- Pop culture
- Bollywood references
- Meme-like humor
- Cricket jokes
- College life

A ₹399 T-shirt became

"This represents me."

That's powerful branding.

Phase 2 (2015–2018): Massive Growth

This was their golden period.

1. Perfect timing

India was experiencing:

- Smartphone boom
- Cheap internet
- Online payments
- Cash on Delivery

Buying online became normal.

2. Affordable pricing

Typical pricing: ₹299–599

Compared to:

Levi's: ₹1500+

Jack & Jones: ₹2000+

People bought multiple designs.

3. Social media mastery

Before Instagram Reels...

Facebook was huge.

Bewakoof created relatable content.

Examples:

- Monday memes
- Exam season jokes
- Relationship humor

People shared posts voluntarily. Marketing became free.

4. Influencer marketing before influencers

Instead of celebrities...

They worked with:

- Meme pages
- College pages
- Small creators

Very low customer acquisition cost.

5. D2C model

- No distributors.
- No retail margins.
- Everything online.
- Higher gross margins.

6. Fast launches

Trending movie? New collection.

Cricket World Cup? New collection.

IPL? New collection.

Marvel movie? Collection.

Speed became an advantage.

Their Biggest Competitive Advantage

They understood **Millennials**. Not fashion. Millennials wanted "I'm different." Every product communicated personality.

Then Everything Changed

Around 2019–2020. The market evolved much faster than Bewakoof did.

Mistake 1

They confused popularity with loyalty.

Customers loved Funny T-shirts.

But that doesn't mean Customers loved Bewakoof.

Huge difference.

When better options appeared...

People switched immediately.

Mistake 2

They stayed a graphic T-shirt brand

Fashion trends evolved.

Consumers started buying

- oversized fits
- minimalist designs
- Korean fashion
- basics
- premium cotton
- co-ord sets

Bewakoof still pushed huge printed graphics. The aesthetic shifted. The brand didn't.

Mistake 3

Quality perception

Consumers became more quality conscious.

People started comparing ₹499 Bewakoof vs ₹599 from

- Zudio
- H&M
- Max
- Westside

Customers felt Fabric quality wasn't improving enough. Print durability became a common complaint.

Mistake 4

Everyone copied them Graphic T-shirts became a commodity.

Suddenly

- Souled Store
- Bonkers Corner
- Snitch (men's fashion)
- Urban Monkey
- Amazon sellers
- Myntra private labels

all sold similar products.

Their differentiation disappeared.

Mistake 5

Slow fashion evolution

They entered categories like

- joggers
- jeans
- shirts
- activewear

But consumers didn't associate Bewakoof with those.

Brand perception stayed "Funny T-shirt company."

Mistake 6

Dependence on discounts

Over time Everything became 50% OFF, 60% OFF, Buy 2 Get 2

Customers stopped believing the original prices.

Discounts became expected. Margins suffered.

Mistake 7

Missing the Gen Z shift

Millennials grew older. Gen Z arrived.

Gen Z values:

- aesthetics
- creators
- clean branding
- micro trends
- quiet fashion
- Pinterest looks

Bewakoof's communication still felt 2018 Facebook humor. The internet had moved to TikTok-style trends (globally) and short-form video culture.

Mistake 8

Offline expansion wasn't a game changer

The company opened physical stores later. But unlike Zudio, stores weren't creating excitement.

Offline came relatively late and wasn't enough to redefine the brand.

Mistake 9

Marketplace dependence

As consumers increasingly shopped on platforms like Myntra and Ajio, product comparison became easier.

On marketplaces, shoppers compare:

- price
- discounts
- reviews

Not brand stories.

That weakens D2C differentiation unless the brand has strong desirability.

Mistake 10

Product-first instead of lifestyle-first

Brands that win today don't sell products.

They sell identities.

For example:

- Souled Store → fandoms
- Snitch → trendy men's fashion
- Uniqlo → everyday quality basics
- Zudio → affordable fast fashion

Bewakoof remained associated mainly with graphic prints rather than evolving into a broader lifestyle aspiration.

Competition Got Smarter

Brand	Positioning
Souled Store	Licensed fandom merchandise + quality improvements
Snitch	Fast-fashion for men
Bonkers Corner	Oversized streetwear
Zudio	Affordable fast fashion with frequent assortment refreshes
Uniqlo	Minimal premium basics
H&M	International fast fashion

Each occupied a clearer space in consumers' minds.

Internal Challenges

Around 2022–2023, the broader D2C funding environment changed. Investors shifted their focus from rapid growth to profitability and sustainable economics. Many digital-first brands, including Bewakoof, faced pressure to optimize costs, improve margins, and reduce customer acquisition expenses.

The Acquisition

A major turning point came when Aditya Birla Fashion and Retail Limited acquired a majority stake in Bewakoof in 2022, valuing the company at around ₹440 crore. The deal gave Bewakoof

access to stronger retail capabilities, while ABFRL gained a youth-focused digital brand. However, integrating with a large fashion group did not immediately restore the brand's earlier cultural relevance.

Did Bewakoof Actually Fail?

No. This is important.

They still:

- Sell online
- Have an app
- Operate offline stores
- Launch collections
- Generate significant revenue

But compared to their peak, they've experienced a sharp decline in mindshare.

In branding, being forgotten is often worse than going bankrupt.

What Could They Have Done Differently?

1. Evolve from "graphic T-shirts" to a broader youth fashion brand earlier.
2. Invest more aggressively in fabric quality and fit.
3. Reduce reliance on perpetual discounts.
4. Build stronger communities and creator collaborations beyond memes.
5. Refresh the brand identity to resonate with Gen Z while retaining loyal millennials.
6. Expand into adjacent categories with a compelling fashion narrative, not just more SKUs.

Key Lessons for Startups

- **A product can go viral. A brand must keep evolving.**
- **Owning a category today doesn't guarantee relevance tomorrow.**
- **Customer identity shifts faster than companies expect.**
- **If your differentiation is easy to copy, competitors eventually will.**
- **Cultural relevance is a renewable asset—you have to earn it repeatedly.**